SAMPLE

The Nature of Wisdom: Hikmah in the

Quran Hikmah (حكمة) in the Quran

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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This free sample contains the Introduction and Chapter 1. The complete book contains the full contents above.

Introduction

The Quran is a book of guidance, but it is also a book of wisdom. From its opening pages to its closing verses, it calls upon the reader to think, to reflect, to understand — to move beyond mere information toward something deeper. That something is hikmah — wisdom. The word appears throughout the Quran in various forms, always pointing to a quality that is more than knowledge, more than intelligence, more than cleverness. It is the ability to see things as they truly are, to judge rightly, to act with understanding, and to align oneself with the truth that Allah has placed in creation and revelation.

Wisdom in the Quran is not an abstract philosophical concept. It is intensely practical. It is the quality that allows a believer to navigate the complexities of life — to be patient when patience is needed, grateful when gratitude is due, just when justice is demanded, and humble when humility is the right response. It is the quality that was given to the prophets in abundance, that Luqman taught his son, and that every believer is invited to seek from Allah.

This book is the first in the Wisdom sub-series of the NurOne project. It explores the concept of hikmah as the Quran presents it: its meaning, its source, its relationship with revelation, its bestowal upon the prophets, the example of Luqman, the wisdom inherent in Allah's commands and decrees, the wisdom hidden in trials, the call to reflection, and the ultimate wisdom of seeking Allah's pleasure. The Quran does not gather its teachings on wisdom into a single chapter. Instead, the concept appears across its pages — in stories, in commands, in parables, and in direct instruction. This book gathers those threads and weaves them together.

Chapter 1: What is Hikmah? — The Meaning of Wisdom in the Quran

The word hikmah appears in the Quran in several forms, and understanding its meaning is the first step toward appreciating its significance. The root of the word — h-k-m — carries the sense of judgment, of deciding between things, of restraining and directing. A hakim is one who judges. Hukm is a judgment or a command. Hikmah is the quality that enables sound judgment — the wisdom to decide rightly and act correctly.

In the Quran, hikmah is closely associated with kitab — the Book, meaning revelation. The two are often mentioned together. Allah says He gave the prophets al-kitab wa al-hikmah — the Book and the Wisdom (2:129, 2:151, 3:81, 3:164, 4:113, 5:110). This pairing is significant. It suggests that hikmah is not identical with the Book but is a companion to it. The Book provides the text, the commandments, the laws. Hikmah provides the understanding to apply them rightly. Knowledge without wisdom is like a sword in the hands of a child — powerful but undirected. Wisdom channels knowledge toward its proper end.

The Quran also uses the word hikmah in a more general sense. In the story of Luqman, Allah says He granted Luqman hikmah (31:12). Luqman was not a prophet in the traditional sense — he was a wise man, a sage. His wisdom is presented through the advice he gave his son, which forms one of the most beloved passages in the Quran (31:12-19). This shows that hikmah is not restricted to prophets. It is a gift that Allah gives to whom He wills, and it is something that all believers should seek.

What distinguishes hikmah from mere knowledge? Knowledge is the accumulation of facts. Wisdom is the ability to understand those facts in their proper context, to see their deeper meaning, and to act accordingly. A person can have extensive knowledge of the Quran's verses but lack the wisdom to understand their application. The Quran warns against this when it describes those who were given knowledge but whose hearts became hardened (39:22, 22:46). Knowledge that does not soften the heart or guide the actions is knowledge without wisdom.

The Quran also connects hikmah with hukm — the act of judging. When Allah says He gave Dawud (David) hukm and wisdom (38:20), the meaning is that He gave him the ability to judge between people with justice and insight. Wisdom in this sense is not passive contemplation. It is active, engaged, and practical. It manifests in decisions, in speech, in action. A wise person speaks at the right time, in the right way, on the right subject. A wise person acts with

foresight and deliberation. A wise person remains silent when silence is better than speech.

The Prophet Muhammad is described in the Quran as one who taught the Book and the Wisdom (2:129, 2:151, 3:164, 62:2). His role was not merely to convey the text of the revelation but to demonstrate its wisdom through his example — his words, his actions, his decisions, his dealings with people. This is why the Sunnah (the prophetic example) is considered a form of hikmah in the Islamic tradition. It is the living demonstration of how the Book's teachings are applied with understanding.

The Quran also says that hikmah has many aspects, and whoever is given hikmah has been given much good (2:269). This verse is striking. It does not say that wisdom has one form or one expression. It says it has many — suggesting that wisdom is multifaceted, contextual, and adaptable. The wisdom of patience is not the same as the wisdom of action. The wisdom of speaking is not the same as the wisdom of silence. The wisdom of war is not the same as the wisdom of peace. Hikmah is the ability to discern which quality is needed in which moment.

It is worth noting that the Quran does not define hikmah in a single verse. Instead, it shows what wisdom looks like through its stories and teachings. The patience of Nuh (Noah) preaching for centuries is wisdom. The determination of Ibrahim (Abraham) to break his father's idols is wisdom. The restraint of Yusuf (Joseph) in not revealing his identity too soon is wisdom. The judgment of Dawud and Sulaiman (Solomon) in settling disputes is wisdom. The advice of Luqman to his son is wisdom. These are not abstract principles. They are living examples of what hikmah looks like in practice.

The Quran also warns against false wisdom — the wisdom of this world that lacks spiritual depth. The Quran describes those who are given knowledge but use it for argument and division rather than guidance (2:146, 3:23). It describes those who follow conjecture instead of certain knowledge (6:116, 10:36). It describes those who are wise in their own estimation but lack the humility that true wisdom requires. True hikmah always begins with the recognition that Allah is the source of all wisdom and that human wisdom is limited and dependent.

In summary, hikmah in the Quran is the God-given ability to understand, judge, and act rightly. It is paired with the Book as its companion and interpreter. It is given to prophets and to non-prophets like Luqman. It is multifaceted and contextual. It is practical, not merely theoretical. And it is always grounded in the awareness that Allah is its source and that human wisdom is always partial and subordinate to divine wisdom.

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